KCR: THE LONG ROAD TO DELHI PG 9

ODISHA TRIBALS: FOR LAND AND IDENTITY PG 14

UPFRONT

Q&A WITH ANTONIO GUTERRES PG 10

VS@99: FEARLESS COMMISSAR PG 20



ANI

HOLDING THE FORT
PM Narendra Modi with CM Jai Ram Thakur in Kullu, Oct. 5

HIMACHAL POLLS

THAKUR & THE REBELS

By Anilesh S. Mahajan

Celebration was not the first thing on BJP national president J.P. Nadda's mind when he arrived at his native Vijaypur village in Himachal Pradesh's Bilaspur district just before Diwali. He had an urgent task on his hands: working with Chief Minister Jai Ram Thakur to mollify party colleagues disgruntled with the distribution of tickets for the assembly polls due on November 12. In a state where no CM has returned to power since 1985, the BJP's strategy to beat anti-incumbency by denying tickets to 11 sitting MLAs, including two ministers, and fielding 23 new faces has, not surprisingly, triggered rebellion within certain sections of the party. The rebels have filed nominations to contest for 14 seats and an internal assessment by the party warns this could damage its prospects in five or six constituencies. For instance, in Banjar, the BJP candidate Surender Shourie will have to take on both Hiteshwar Singh—scion of the erstwhile royal family of Kullu—who is running as an Independent and the Congress candidate Khimi Ram Sharma, a former BJP state unit chief. Sharma crossed over to the grand old party in July, which has cost his father the Kullu seat, where the party has fielded teacher-turned-politician Purushottam Thakur. In a bid to put his house in order ahead of the election campaign, CM Thakur has been shuttling between